

# AUSTRALASIA AND OCEANIA



AUSTRALIA, New Zealand, Papua New Guinea, and the nearby islands are collectively called Australasia. The wider

area known as Oceania also includes the island groups of Melanesia, Micronesia, and Polynesia and spans a huge area in the South Pacific Ocean. Australia is the largest country and a continent in its own right. Although many Pacific islands were once European colonies, the region now has closer trade links with Asia.



## Coral islands

Many of the thousands of tiny islands in Oceania are the peaks of undersea volcanic mountains that are just breaking the surface of the Pacific Ocean. Reefs of coral, teeming with tropical fish, often build up close to the islands' sandy shores.

## Physical features

Australasia and Oceania include a wide range of landscapes, from tropical rainforest in northern areas to the arid desert of central Australia. Many islands are volcanic, with sandy beaches, high mountains, and a constant threat of earthquakes.



## Geysers

These occur in New Zealand where hot rock heats water in an underground chamber. As the water boils, a fountain of scalding water and steam shoots 500 m (1,640 ft) into the air.

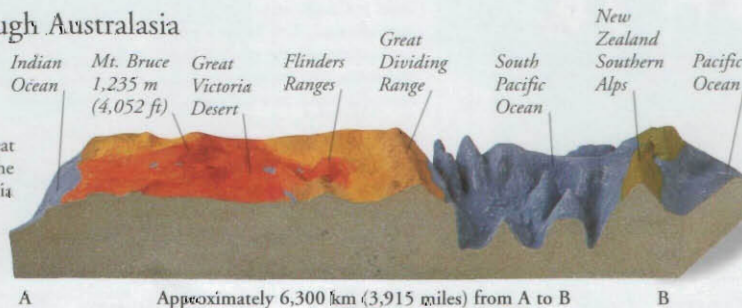


## Pinnacles Desert

Tall pinnacles of limestone rise from the sand in parts of Australia's hot, dry Western Desert. These unusually shaped rocks have been sculpted by the eroding action of plant roots and harsh winds over the last 25,000 years.

## Cross-section through Australasia

Australia is a largely flat continent, with low mountains in the southwest and a desert centre. The highest mountains are the Great Dividing Range in the east. The Pacific Ocean between Australia and New Zealand dips to 5,000 m (16,405 ft). The Southern Alps run down New Zealand's South Island.



## AUSTRALASIA AND OCEANIA FACTS

AREA 8,508,238 sq km

(3,285,048 sq miles)

POPULATION 29,700,000

NUMBER OF COUNTRIES 14

HIGHEST POINT Mt. Wilhelm (Papua New Guinea) 4,509 m (14,794 ft)

LONGEST RIVER Murray Darling (Australia) 3,750 km (2,330 miles)

BIGGEST LAKE Lake Eyre (Australia) 9,583 sq km (3,700 miles)